CAPABILITY BASELINE / S03 / PRE-AUDIT ASSESSMENT

PSS Acceptance 360 Current-State Capability and Gap Assessment

Evidence-ranked baseline • reusable-asset candidates • critical blockers • technical verification plan • management sign-off requirements

Prepared for the proposed PSS Research, Product & Business Development programme

18 October 2026 | Version 1.0 | Confidential - discussion / pre-audit only

CONTROL	STATUS / ACCOUNTABILITY
Document ID	PSS-A360-S03-001
Programme linkage	S04/V01 Master Research, Validation & Feasibility Terms of Reference
Status	Desk-based assessment; no PSS internal system access, product demonstrations or signed attestations
Prepared from perspective of	Research, Product & Business Development Division (proposed management role)
Technical baseline owner	PSS Technology / Operations - nomination pending
Independent reviewers	Legal / Compliance; CISO / Risk; Finance; Internal Audit as applicable - pending
Evidence cut-off	18 October 2026; public and user-provided project materials only
Decision enabled	Approve controlled current-state verification; DO NOT approve build, production pilot or investment on this report

Executive conclusion

Current recommendation: Protect and exploit validated legacy processing assets, but do not assume that PSS Pay, gateway, national QR access, merchant operations or bank adapters are ready for Acceptance 360 without owner demonstrations, contracts, measured production data and security/regulatory assurance. **The priority is asset verification, not platform procurement.**

Source discipline: A public announcement establishes that a claim was made; it does not prove a system is production-ready, compliant for a specific use case, owned by PSS, available for reuse, or commercially bankable.

1 What this assessment decides - and does not

S03 is the mandatory baseline for the later product requirements (P01), solution design (P02), technical/regulatory feasibility (F02/F03), current-product performance validation (V05), supplier analysis (P04) and integrated investment case (F01/F05). It is a structured pre-audit grounded in public disclosures and prior project materials. No management interviews, privileged operational dashboards, contracts, licences or test execution were provided.

1.1 Management questions

1. Which PSS assets are publicly evidenced and likely worth reusing?
2. Which assets are publicly reported but internally unverified, and which Acceptance 360 capabilities are presently only proposals?
3. What precisely must the named owner produce or demonstrate to convert a claim into a verified current-state fact?
4. Which uncertainties are hard launch blockers, which primarily affect cost and time, and which may justify removing a proposed module?
5. What should the architecture and investment team assume for early options analysis while evidence is being gathered?

1.2 Rules for classification

TAG	WHAT IT MEANS	DECISION WEIGHT
REG	Regulator / official standards source documents the external regime or licence register.	Reliable for the specific published fact, not a substitute for original PSS licence conditions.
CO	A PSS, CEO or partner public statement exists.	Evidence of a reported claim; requires operational and contractual proof.
HIST	Historical PSS product / annual / partner publication.	Evidence of historical activity; current capacity and cost unverified.
GAP	Insufficient relevant current-state proof supplied.	No claim of capability, compliance or suitability permitted.
DES	Proposed Acceptance 360 product or control requirement.	A design objective only, not an installed PSS component.
INT	Controlled internal primary evidence, once received and authenticated.	May support current-state verification after reviewer attestation.

1.3 Readiness is not the same as publicity

An announced product may be live for a limited bank or card rail, may depend on a supplier SDK, or may have certification coverage narrower than the proposed new uses. Conversely, a historically mature switch may not offer multitenant merchant servicing, APIs, subledger-style reconciliation or per-merchant pricing. S03 does not assign maturity scores without verified observations.

Relevant antecedents: [D01] supplied Last-Mile Volume 1 (received Parts A-B7), [D02] Acceptance 360 strategic redesign v3, and [D03] S04/V01 Terms of Reference. Their planning statements are not PSS-approved specifications.

2 Public record: what is evidenced

CURRENT-STATE TOPIC	DOCUMENTED RECORD / LIMIT
Regulated switching	NBE public PSO register lists Premier Switch Solution S.C as commercialised switch operator, PSO/001/2013, dated 15 February 2013 [P01]. It does not provide licence annexes or scope for new activities.
New POS / gateway authority	August 2026 sector coverage and PSS/CEO statements report new POS-operator and payment-gateway licences [P02-P03]. Licence originals, numbers, conditions and current status were not provided.
SoftPOS / PSS Pay	PSS/CEO report a Visa/Mastercard-certified phone acceptance offer [P03]. PCI-listing identity, contract rights, card acceptance scope, bank integrations, device eligibility and measured usage are unknown.

CURRENT-STATE TOPIC	DOCUMENTED RECORD / LIMIT
Legacy operations	PSS presents historical switch, POS/ATM processing, vendor relationships and POS product trading [P04-P05]. Current service inventory, SLAs, capacity, product profitability and software entitlements have not been inspected.
3-D Secure / PSS Secure	PSS disclosed an ACS aligned with EMV 3DS 2.2 in August 2025, including four onboarded member banks at that time; a later PSS/CEO claim refers to seven partner banks [P06-P03]. Neither is proof it belongs in a face-to-face QR payment path.
Card personalisation	PSS announced Visa approval for card personalisation and card preparation services in August 2025 [P07]. Separate from a merchant acquiring or SoftPOS approval.
Security posture	PSS disclosed 2025 PCI DSS v4.0.1 Level 1 assessment as certified until 8 July 2026 [P08]. Current AOC, entities/services in scope and renewal evidence are missing.
National QR / rails	NBE publishes interoperable QR standards; EthSwitch publishes QR scheme resources [P09-P10]. Neither demonstrates PSS is approved to connect, originate merchant credentials or provide acquiring services on any particular route.
Policy / privacy	NBE NDPS 2026-2030 remains labelled draft on the NBE page [P11]. Ethiopia Personal Data Protection Proclamation 1321/2024 is in force [P12]. Both require correct current legal interpretation.

3 Capability inventory A - existing core and adjacent assets

Disposition codes: CANDIDATE = evaluate for reuse; DEPENDENT = only if external rights/terms allow; SEPARATE = do not merge into merchant service without a distinct case; UNPROVEN = no demonstrated baseline.

ID	ASSET	EVIDENCE	A360 RELEVANCE	POSITION	REQUIRED INTERNAL PROOF
A01	Switch transaction routing	HIST / REG	Bank routing / message translation	CANDIDATE	Current topology, product list, message flows, TPS/latency/capacity tests.
A02	ATM driving and support	HIST	Operations discipline / support	SEPARATE	Current footprint, SLA, monitoring, staff and cost allocation.
A03	POS switch / terminal management	HIST / CO	Merchant acceptance back end	CANDIDATE	Terminal inventory, acquiring flows, software licences, deployment and merchant logs.
A04	Card issuance/personalisation	CO	Bank relationship / card supply	SEPARATE	Visa approval scope, audited service costs; no transfer to acceptance claimed.
A05	International scheme card rails	CO	Eligible card acceptance path	DEPENDENT	Issuer/acquirer routing contracts, scheme participation and transaction types.
A06	Bank technical relationships	HIST	Potential reusable bank interfaces	CANDIDATE	Bank-by-bank connection matrix, IP/API rights, contract limits and change costs.
A07	Current incident/operations desk	HIST / GAP	Operate service support base	UNPROVEN	24x7 coverage, ticket reports, exception backlog, staffing and unit costs.
A08	Security operations/HSM/key systems	HIST / GAP	Control reuse (restricted)	UNPROVEN	Current architecture, scope evidence, key custody, access logging and ownership.

4 Capability inventory B - newer product lines and permissions

ID	ASSET	EVIDENCE	A360 RELEVANCE	POSITION	REQUIRED INTERNAL PROOF
A09	PSS Pay SoftPOS	CO	Accept / eligible tap	DEPENDENT	Live demo; version; exact MPoC/other scheme path; certified provider; transaction metrics.
A10	Payment gateway	CO	Connect / e-commerce	UNPROVEN	Gateway topology, deployment status, merchants/banks, scheme/rail rights, SLA.
A11	POS-operator authority	CO / REG gap	Accept / processing	UNPROVEN	Original NBE grant and annex; licensed entity and permitted merchant activities.
A12	Gateway-operator authority	CO / REG gap	Connect	UNPROVEN	Original NBE grant and annex; contracting/funds-flow limits.

ID	ASSET	EVIDENCE	A360 RELEVANCE	POSITION	REQUIRED INTERNAL PROOF
A13	PSS Secure ACS/3DS	CO	Card-not-present assurance	SEPARATE	Certified ACS inventory, clients/contracts, scope and profit/cost; distinct 3DS line.
A14	PSS Trading tech unit	CO	Build/buy/partner supplier	DEPENDENT	Incorporation, ownership, service list, IP rights, transfer pricing and procurement.
A15	POS equipment procurement	HIST	Optional device channel	CANDIDATE	Inventory, warranties, terminal app certifications and device service costs.
A16	Vendor technology agreements	HIST	Licensing / integrations	DEPENDENT	S2M and other licence/support contracts; source and derivative-work rights.

5 Capability inventory C - unverified critical operating capabilities

ID	CAPABILITY	EVIDENCE	A360 NEED	POSITION	REQUIRED INTERNAL PROOF
A17	EthQR acquiring / QR issuance	GAP	Accept + Connect	UNPROVEN	Signed EthSwitch scheme/participant status, bank sponsor, QR issuance and test messages.
A18	Wallet / A2A interoperability	GAP	Accept + Connect	UNPROVEN	Actual partner APIs, contracts, permitted rails, prices, settlement and message coverage.
A19	Merchant master & roles	GAP	Operate	UNPROVEN	Bank-controlled merchant IDs, sponsor mapping, service entitlements, onboarding audit.
A20	Merchant reconciliation / disputes	GAP	Operate (core differentiator)	UNPROVEN	Real end-to-end states, ledger matching, reversal/dispute traces, exception ageing.
A21	Multi-bank tenant segregation	GAP	Connect + Operate	UNPROVEN	Architecture, RBAC, logical isolation test, metadata/PII and audit separation.
A22	Merchant portal / insights	GAP	Operate + Grow	UNPROVEN	Existing module demos, data permissions, usability and contract rights.
A23	Active merchant support economics	GAP	Commercial feasibility	UNPROVEN	Ticket volume, field dispatch, KYC handoff, device support, unit cost by cohort.
A24	Production telemetry / status truth	GAP	Safety and assurance	UNPROVEN	Trace samples of unknown, timeout, retry, reversal, settlement finality and alerting.
A25	Bank contracted pricing and demand	GAP	Business viability	UNPROVEN	Current tariffs, bank terms, budget owners and willingness to pay.
A26	Privacy/processor role mapping	GAP	All data handling	UNPROVEN	DPA, purpose/retention matrix, lawful basis and breach escalation procedures.

5.1 Why unverified does not mean absent

Many of these functions may exist inside a bank service desk, switching reconciliation process, vendor product or PSS private operational system. The evidence gap records only that present materials do not prove their fit for a new multibank merchant service. It is not a finding of technical failure or absence.

5.2 Most consequential gap

The current project hypothesis treats PSS Operate as the likely highest-value initial module. The public baseline does NOT establish merchant-level reconciliation, exception management, multi-tenant merchant provisioning or bank-specific service economics. S03 must demonstrate or disprove those capabilities before P01 claims they are already delivered.

6 Product-line fit and proposed reuse boundaries

PROPOSED MODULE	POSSIBLE REUSE	WHAT MUST NOT BE ASSUMED	INITIAL STRATEGY
Accept	PSS Pay, POS services, terminal sourcing [A03,A09,A15]	SoftPOS listing covers proposed device/bank configuration; merchant digital payment activity exists.	Optional delivery channel, gated by scheme/legal/device tests.
Connect	Switch routing, existing bank interfaces, possible gateway [A01,A06,A10]	Legacy switch integration automatically provides merchant APIs, all QR wallets, or open-banking permissions.	First test bank-specific adapter and rail-rights reuse.
Operate	Existing operational discipline and transaction logs [A07,A20,A24]	Present PSS infrastructure already holds merchant settlement truth or reliable exception engine.	Preferred customer problem to test; currently capability-unproven.
Grow	Existing card/security know-how and possible reporting [A04,A13,A22]	PSS Secure is a QR authentication component or credit/data analytics are pre-authorised.	Defer commercial scope until pricing, data law and capacity validate.
Agent Connect	Possible future bank/partner integrations	PSS is already operator of national shared agent scheme.	Outside first release; partnership exploration only.

7 Target boundary: reuse without duplicated national infrastructure

The architecture below is a requirements boundary, not an assertion of implementation. Bank duties depend on real contracts and applicable rules; PSS also retains its own licensing, processing and security responsibilities. A new product must make each participant's authority explicit.

LAYER / RESPONSIBLE ENTITY	REQUIRED ROLE	CURRENT EVIDENCE STATUS
Bank / acquiring institution	Economic buyer; merchant agreement and account; KYC/AML decisions where applicable; final merchant crediting and customer remediation responsibilities in signed agreement.	Sponsor and contracting model not confirmed.
PSS Acceptance 360: optional Accept	Bank-authorised merchant provisioning; certified SoftPOS/POS; applicable interoperable QR acceptance presentation.	Legacy POS and SoftPOS publicly reported; actual configuration unknown.
PSS Acceptance 360: Connect	Signed bank adapters, secure routing, authorised national scheme messages, traceable API orchestration.	Legacy routing evidenced historically; A360 adapter and QR access unverified.
PSS Acceptance 360: Operate	Merchant status evidence, exception queues, retries/idempotency, dispute support, reconciliation records and bank dashboards.	Specific merchant service functionality unverified.
External schemes / networks	EthSwitch, issuers, acquirers, international card schemes, wallet partners perform the functions their rules and contracts assign.	External infrastructure exists; PSS participation rights to confirm.
PSS Secure / PSS Trading	3DS for applicable e-commerce and optional technology supply under separate contracts.	Corporate statements exist; no cross-use or affiliate award assumed.

7.1 Transaction truth is a control, not a marketing feature

Before pilots, PSS and the lead bank must sign an authoritative status hierarchy and clearing/settlement responsibilities for each rail. The design baseline requires INITIATED, PENDING, CONFIRMED, FAILED, REVERSED and NEEDS_RECONCILIATION states, tied to traceable rail and bank references [D02]. A local success animation or timeout must never be treated as authorised confirmation.

7.2 Technical non-functional criteria to measure

- Integrations: API/protocol coverage, bank-specific transformations, certification lead time and end-to-end trace IDs.

- Security: exact in-scope entities and products, key management, merchant tenant isolation, device attestation, vulnerability closure.
- Reliability: observed monthly uptime, p95/p99 latency, retry/idempotency behaviour, recovery time and support response.
- Reconciliation: match rate, unmatched age, reversals, dispute turnaround, failure attribution, legal finality.
- Cost: operating and vendor licence fixed costs, per-merchant support, per-transaction rail costs, integration investment.

8 Critical gap register - immediate hard blockers

GAP	WHAT IS MISSING	CATEGORY	PRIMARY OWNER	CLOSE-OUT EVIDENCE
G01	POS/gateway licence originals & conditions	HARD	Legal / Compliance	Grant+annex mapped to each proposed function.
G02	Current PCI DSS AOC and exact covered entities	HARD	CISO / Compliance	Valid attestation, assessor evidence, scope and corrective actions.
G03	SoftPOS solution/SDK and scheme acceptance path	HARD	CISO / Product	Provider, MPoC/other applicable listing + network approval + exact configuration.
G04	EthQR/acquiring rights and bank contract boundary	HARD	Legal / Network	Scheme rule, participant rights, sponsored-bank approval, message certification.
G05	Licensed funds flow and dispute/settlement liability	HARD	Legal / Operations	Rail-wise RACI, merchant agreement, settlement and loss allocation.
G06	Transaction state finality and unknown outcomes	HARD	Technology / Risk	Reproducible pending, reversal, duplicate and reconciliation trace tests.
G07	Merchant and bank data access lawfulness	HARD	DPO / Legal	Lawful basis, contract, retention, minimisation and incident duty.
G08	Cross-bank logical isolation and privileged access	HARD	CISO / Architecture	Tenant threat model; access tests; secure logs and pen-test plan.
G09	Resilience and incident response for scoped flows	HARD	Ops / CISO	Current DR/BCP tests, bank escalation and outage runbooks.
G10	Live pilot sponsor and bank legal obligations	HARD at G2	Business Dev / Legal	Signed scope of work, product owner, bank risk acceptance and customer terms.

HARD = cannot recommend a live pilot for affected flows while unresolved. Internal feasibility research and non-production synthetic testing may continue under appropriate authority.

9 Critical gap register - cost, practicality and business-model choices

GAP	WHAT IS MISSING	CLASS	OWNER	CLOSE-OUT EVIDENCE
G11	PSS Pay merchant cohorts and acceptance performance	HIGH	Product / Ops	12-month de-identified cohort dataset, declines, support, refunds.
G12	Existing PSS merchant-support unit costs	HIGH	Finance / Ops	Payroll/vendor/support/device service allocation by customer segment.
G13	Bank-by-bank integration rights and adaptation effort	HIGH	Technology / Legal	Interface inventory, SLA, ownership, rights and estimated effort.
G14	Merchant-level reconciliation service availability	HIGH	Ops / Technology	Existing screenshots, matching rules, backlog, dispute SLAs.
G15	Exact gateway deployed capacity and customer set	HIGH	Product / Technology	Live diagrams, release history, uptime, clients and contracts.
G16	Bank willingness to pay and competitive substitute	HIGH	BD / Finance	Economic buyer interview, pricing ranges, bank cost counterfactual.
G17	PSS Trading entity, ownership and supplier terms	MEDIUM	Legal / Procurement	Registration, contracts, pricing, IP and related-party policy.
G18	Merchant device/OS/NFC and connectivity	HIGH	Research / Product	Cohort device audit, network conditions, onboarding costs.
G19	Vendor change rights, licences and concentration	HIGH	Technology / Procurement	Contract extracts, upgrade roadmap, exit options and dependency map.
G20	Non-shareholder bank neutrality and pricing	HIGH	Strategy / Legal	Access policy, technical segregation, pricing principles, conflict controls.
G21	Consumer/merchant complaint lifecycle	HIGH	Operations / Legal	Backlog, correction process, notification SLA, bank hand-offs.

GAP	WHAT IS MISSING	CLASS	OWNER	CLOSE-OUT EVIDENCE
G22	Data rights for analytics and Grow services	MEDIUM	DPO / Product	Purpose-specific impact assessment and bank permission.

9.1 Prioritisation rule

Order work by (i) legal/PCI/data safety; (ii) proof that existing assets can deliver one bank use case; (iii) actual incremental cost and bank purchase commitment; then (iv) modular expansion. A scorecard can be constructed only after an evidence owner records proof and an independent reviewer checks it. Do not colour-code empty data as a "green" capability.

9.2 Three possible S03 outcomes

OUTCOME	TRIGGER	NEXT APPROACH
REUSE FIRST	Current approved routes, bank interfaces and reconciliation controls satisfy first use case.	Narrow scope to Connect + Operate and cost actual incremental upgrades.
PARTNER / BUY	SoftPOS/QR or merchant operations require licensed third-party components with viable contracts.	Costed partner integration; independent procurement and certification check.
DO NOT BUILD	No lawful scheme path, weak bank benefit, prohibitive vendor restrictions or unresolved false-success risk.	Retain existing lines, redesign as narrow operations tool or stop programme.

10 Verification tests - no production changes authorised

Technical verification begins with demonstrations and controlled inspection of existing records. Where functional tests are needed, use approved synthetic data in a bank-sanctioned test environment. Never connect unapproved applications to production systems or process real customer funds under this study.

ID	TEST	METHOD	PASS EVIDENCE
T01	Baseline route trace	One authorised existing ATM/POS transaction trace with reference chain.	Trace through switch + bank/rail; documented reconciliation hand-off.
T02	PSS Pay eligibility	Representative eligible and ineligible phones, Android versions, NFC and SDK configs.	Document expected acceptance, attestation and rejection outcomes.
T03	Status timeout	Synthetic timeout then delayed authoritative confirmation.	Merchant remains PENDING until verified final status.
T04	Duplicate / retry	Replay idempotency key and network retry.	No double final credit/charge; events deduplicated and traceable.
T05	Reversal/dispute	Authorised refund, reversal and dispute pathways.	Correct correlation, merchant/bank notice and ledger matching.
T06	Two-bank isolation	Synthetic tenant A attempts access to tenant B merchant.	Denied; full audit logging and privacy-safe evidence.
T07	QR scheme route	Certifiable EthQR onboarding and issuer/acquirer test against official rights.	Contractual authority, schema compliance and rail acknowledgement.
T08	Recovery/BCP	Sandbox failover or tabletop with documented recovery objectives.	No data loss beyond policy; reconciles delayed and queued messages.
T09	Bank adapter repeatability	Port synthetic reference messages for two bank interface variants.	Incremental cost/time measured; no hidden custom dependency.
T10	Support and costing	Match anonymised real ticket cohorts to cost and merchant journeys.	Auditable unit cost and customer support failure drivers.

11 Evidence request pack - controlling asset owners

Request only the minimum records needed to verify current capabilities. Default to metadata and de-identified aggregates; access to sensitive diagrams, contracts and transaction samples must be approved and logged. Requested deadlines below are relative to an authorised Day 0, not automatic.

REQ	CUSTODIAN	RECORD / DATA SET	DUE	CLOSES
R01	Legal	NBE switch, POS and gateway licence grants, endorsements and conditions	D10	G01,G05

REQ	CUSTODIAN	RECORD / DATA SET	DUE	CLOSES
R02	Legal	Merchant/acquirer/participant agreements, acquiring authority, complaints/liability mapping	D20	G04,G05
R03	Legal / DPO	Data-processing agreements, privacy impact, retention and data sharing approvals	D15	G07
R04	CISO	Current PCI DSS AOC, assessor report scope and renewal status	D10	G02
R05	CISO / Product	SoftPOS provider, exact product versions/listings and payment-brand approvals	D10	G03
R06	Technology	As-is system landscape and major data/transaction flow diagrams	D20	A01,A10
R07	Technology	Approved interfaces by bank: contracts, protocol, change rights and costs	D25	G13
R08	Product	PSS Pay release versions, merchant onboarding terms, roadmap and supported devices	D15	G11
R09	Operations	12-month product transaction outcome extracts by merchant cohort (de-identified)	D25	G11
R10	Operations	Anonymised incident, refund, reversal, complaint and exception samples	D25	G06,G21
R11	Ops / Technology	Merchant reconciliation and status-truth demonstrations, runbooks and logs	D25	G14
R12	Technology	Gateway live status, topologies, certificates, API catalogues and service SLAs	D25	G15
R13	Network / Legal	EthSwitch/EthQR participation, scheme test approvals and approved interfaces	D25	G04
R14	Network / Legal	International card/acquirer rights, scheme certificates, chargeback terms	D25	G03,G05
R15	Finance	12-month line-of-business actual revenues, variable costs and central allocations	D30	G12
R16	Finance	Hosting, security, certification, vendor licence, cloud/DC, device and support cost	D30	G12,G19
R17	Procurement	Technology contracts, support SLAs, term/termination, IP, exit/renewal rights	D25	G19
R18	Legal / Procurement	PSS Trading registration, related-party rules and proposed supplier obligations	D25	G17
R19	Ops / CISO	Pen tests, vulnerability logs, privileged access controls, DR/BCP tests	D25	G08,G09
R20	Bank liaison	Lead-bank current merchant acquiring operating process and core system interfaces	D35	G10
R21	Business Dev	Bank purchase owner, present alternative, indicative price, budget authority	D45	G16
R22	Research	Merchant device, connectivity and transaction workflow audit per target segment	D45	G18
R23	Governance	Policy for shareholder vs non-shareholder bank access and pricing	D30	G20
R24	Company Secretariat	Board/committee delegations, approved strategy, product and spend authorities	D15	Governance

D10 = target 10 days after formally authorised programme Day 0; every target depends on access approval. Where records cannot be shared, seek a controlled inspection, attested summary or independent reviewer certification instead.

12 Verification method and scoring - to be completed, not assumed

Each asset receives two separate judgments: evidence completeness and actual operational suitability. None is scored in this draft. Corporate press releases do not earn operational-maturity levels.

EVIDENCE LEVEL	OPERATIONAL MATURITY LEVEL (ONLY AFTER TEST)
E0: no evidence beyond a proposal	M0: not installed / not available for tested purpose
E1: dated public claim or historical description	M1: demonstrable prototype / laboratory service
E2: authenticated contract, licence, inventory or scoped attestation	M2: operational for limited named participants or use cases
E3: controlled demo / service logs + owner signed validation	M3: supported production operation with measured SLA and repeatability
E4: independent reproducibility, risk review and evidence trail	M4: repeatable, portable bank onboarding with audited controls

Working sign-off template for every A01-A26 record: asset ID | accountable owner | source URI/hash | contract/licence rights | evidence level E0-E4 | maturity M0-M4 | observation date | tested use cases | restrictions | cost/run-rate | current gaps | reviewer name/date | proposed reuse decision.

13 Fifteen / thirty / forty-five day execution plan

WINDOW	REQUIRED ACTIONS	CHECKPOINT / EXIT STANDARD
D00-D05	Nominations, data request authority, restricted data room, owner workshops, conflict controls.	Sponsor accepts scope; no access before Legal/CISO terms.
D06-D15	Licences, PCI/SoftPOS identifiers, system maps and gateway/PSS Pay commercial inventory.	Early red-flag memo; stop or redirect prohibited flow.
D16-D30	Controlled legacy switch/POS, SoftPOS, merchant reconciliation, security and operations demos; actual Finance cost baseline.	Owner-attested A01-A26 inventory, unresolved blockers and quantified effort ranges.
D31-D45	Second-bank adapter option, merchant device tests, bank sponsor discussions, vendor agreement review.	Validated reuse decisions; dependencies to P01/P02/F02/F03 and updated Gate 1 gap register.

13.1 Functional responsibility & independent challenge

FUNCTION	ACCOUNTABILITY	REVIEW / NON-DELEGABLE CONTROL
RPB&D	Study coordination, product mapping, bank/merchant use cases, evidence register.	Must not self-certify licence, security, actual audited cost or external contracts.
Technology / Ops	Owned system inventory, live or synthetic demonstrations, capabilities, estimates.	CISO checks security; Ops signs runbooks and incident evidence.
Legal / Compliance	Original licence, partner rights, bank outsourcing, customer data, national rules.	Written red-flag interpretation; no launch permission inferred from strategy.
CISO / Risk	Certification and security scope, threat tests, operations risk and dissent.	Document unresolved severe findings and separate reviewer disposition.
Finance / CFO	Actual costs, baseline product unit economics and reused asset opportunity costs.	Independent costing/forecast validation; avoid double counting existing sunk costs.
Procurement / Company Secretary	Affiliate eligibility, vendor licensing, approvals and conflicts of interest.	PSS Trading evaluated under ordinary supplier controls and delegation rules.
Sponsor bank (prospective)	Commercial terms, acquiring responsibilities, merchant need and counterfactual.	Bank must sign its own readiness and commercial case; not presumed committed.

13.2 Conditions for calling S03 "validated"

6. All A01-A26 assets have a named owner and E-level; unverified items remain explicit.
7. No critical G01-G10 gap is represented as closed without authenticated documentary or reproducible test evidence.
8. Technology, Legal/Compliance, CISO/Risk and Finance independently review their relevant records and register dissents.
9. Every proposed reused asset has a documented permission/cost/operating caveat and bank use-case fit.
10. The approved S03 summary freezes its evidence cut-off and links to source hashes; the document is not revised retroactively to conceal negative evidence.

14 Impact on business and product options

S03 does not preselect the build architecture. Instead it narrows permissible business cases using the following evidence conditions.

STRATEGIC PATH	S03 EVIDENCE THAT WOULD SUPPORT IT	EVIDENCE THAT WOULD ARGUE AGAINST IT
Option A: Full Acceptance 360	Four modules reusable under verified rights; bank sponsor funds breadth and cost is acceptable.	Major missing modules, weak cross-sell rights, unsupported fixed cost or unlicensed acceptance.
Option B: Connect + Operate	Bank adapter and reconciliation evidence exist or incremental build is affordable; bank benefits measurable.	Current bank alternative already provides equal capability; merchant-level truth cannot be proven.
Option C: PSS Pay extension	Device/scheme pathway confirmed; bank merchant cohorts repeat use and low support costs.	Limited NFC adoption, unresolved certification/transaction status, thin bank margin.

STRATEGIC PATH	S03 EVIDENCE THAT WOULD SUPPORT IT	EVIDENCE THAT WOULD ARGUE AGAINST IT
Option D: Partner-led	Licensed partners provide QR, SoftPOS, merchant ops at acceptable TCO with data-rights controls.	Opaque vendor margins, lock-in, scheme conflicts or untestable merchant status.
Option E: No new build	Current legacy portfolio remains valuable; limited net value from merchant infrastructure.	A verified, funded and repeatable buyer pain point would counter the stop case.

14.1 Preliminary (pre-verification) prioritisation

Research first: Connect and Operate, because bank-facing reconciliation, exceptions and integration economics can potentially be tested without depending on national merchant rollout or speculative fees. Do NOT mark these modules as "already available". Validate PSS Pay as a bounded Accept channel. Keep PSS Secure as a separate service and Grow/Agent Connect outside initial cost commitments.

15 Feasibility and investment hand-offs

DOWNSTREAM DOCUMENT	REQUIRED S03 TRANSFER	DO NOT ALLOW
V05 Existing product performance	Attested PSS Pay/gateway and POS merchant performance, cohorts, declines, incidents, device costs.	Claims of active merchants or success rates from untested press statements.
F02 Technical feasibility	System/service diagrams, verified integration rights, scalability, security/PCI facts and tested failure cases.	Generic architecture scoring without exact existing product interfaces.
F03 Legal/regulatory feasibility	Licence grants, subsidiary roles, scheme terms, bank obligations, data roles and unresolved issues.	"Permitted because draft NDPS proposes it" reasoning.
F04/F05 Pricing & financial study	Actual PSS product run-rate, bank servicing economics, vendor costs, partner options.	Arbitrary tariff, subsidised ROI or double-counting sunk infrastructure.
P01/P02 Product & solution design	Prioritised bank problems, reusable interfaces, tested statuses, certification-constrained acceptance channels.	Single monolithic platform imposed before capability and buyer evidence.
P04 Build-buy-partner	Licence/IP/affiliate procurement terms and indicative scoped supplier price ranges.	Presumptive award to PSS Trading or a legacy technology vendor.
E01 Executive memo	Management summary of proven facts, open blockers, financial trade-offs and clear scope recommendation.	Presenting this S03 desktop review as a signed PSS operational audit.

16 Management recommendation & decision note

Recommendation 1 - Approve a controlled current-state capability verification under the already proposed feasibility mandate, including access to licence, product, transaction, vendor and security records through authorised PSS custodians.

Recommendation 2 - Require a named Technology/Operations asset owner and separate Legal, CISO/Risk, Finance and Procurement review, with written evidence and explicit unresolved-issue handling.

Recommendation 3 - Use verified reuse evidence to choose a narrower Connect + Operate, PSS Pay-focused, partner-led or no-build path. Do not pre-authorise a full platform, live merchant activity or any new capital commitment.

16.1 Management signature and disagreement record

REVIEW / SIGN-OFF	NAME / SIGNATURE	DATE / STATUS
Prepared by - Research, Product & Business Development	_____	Pending
Technology / Operations validation	_____	Pending
Legal / Compliance licence and scheme review	_____	Pending
CISO / Risk security and resilience challenge	_____	Pending
CFO / Finance cost and reuse economics	_____	Pending
Procurement / affiliate integrity	_____	Pending
CEO / Executive direction	_____	Pending

Dissent and limitations: _____

Unresolved launch blockers and action owners: _____

No signatures or approvals have been received. The lines above are placeholders for formal institution-specific review under its actual internal governance.

Annex A Provenance and source register

D01 User-supplied PSS Last-Mile Acceptance Ecosystem Executive Document Package, Vol 1, 18 Oct 2026 | Supplied first volume, text stops after Part B7; earlier model and market context.

D02 PSS Acceptance 360 Strategic Redesign v3, 18 Oct 2026 | Management concept: four modules, boundary rules and options; not established current system.

D03 PSS A360 S04/V01 Master Research, Validation and Feasibility TOR, 18 Oct 2026 | Methodology, hypotheses, research-control and approval plan.

P01 NBE - Payment Instrument Issuers/System Operators | https://nbe.gov.et/payment-instrument-issuers-system-operators/

P02 Shega - Premier Switch Expands Into the Checkout, 30 Aug 2026 | https://www.shega.co/news/premier-switch-expands-into-the-checkout-with-po-s-gateway-license

P03 PSS/CEO public corporate transformation statement, Sep 2026 | https://www.linkedin.com/posts/amhatadesse_pss-premierswitchsolutions-rebranding-activity-7499304707589357568-BMtC

P04 PSS - Trading of payment products | https://psseth.com/?page_id=3365

P05 PSS - S2M technology alliance, 24 Sep 2024 | https://psseth.com/?p=6375

P06 PSS - Mastercard ACS/3-D Secure release, 15 Aug 2025 | https://psseth.com/?p=7053

P07 PSS - Visa-approved card personalisation vendor, 1 Aug 2025 | https://psseth.com/?p=7039

P08 PSS - PCI DSS Level 1 2025 release and validity date | https://psseth.com/?p=7035

P09 NBE - National Interoperable QR Code Standard | https://nbe.gov.et/eipqrc/

P10 EthSwitch - Scheme and EthQR resources | https://ethswitch.com/homepage/resourcesinformation/

P11 NBE - Draft National Digital Payments Strategy 2026-2030 | https://nbe.gov.et/ndps/

P12 Ethiopia Ministry of Justice - Personal Data Protection Proclamation 1321/2024 | https://justice.gov.et/en/law/personal-data-protection-proclamation/

P13 PCI SSC - Mobile Payments on COTS (MPoC) | https://www.pcisecuritystandards.org/standards/mobile-payments-on-cots-mpoc/

P14 PCI SSC - searchable MPoC solution listings | https://listings.pcisecuritystandards.org/assessors_and_solutions/mpoc_solutions?agree=true

P15 PCI SSC - CPoC sunset transition note | https://www.pcisecuritystandards.org/standards/contactless-payments-on-cots-cpoc/

Annex B Technical/legal interpretation notes

- The public NBE register is evidence of the displayed legacy switch licence, not proof that newer PSS grants are invalid. A discrepancy between public listings and company announcements is a verification question, not an accusation.
- As of 18 October 2026, the stated 8 July 2026 expiry date belongs to PSS's publicly available 2025 PCI DSS announcement. It does not prove that PSS failed to renew. Verify current AOC and current in-scope products.
- PCI SSC describes MPoC and publishes solution listings; the applicable card-brand rules and listing pathway depend on the actual vendor, version, devices and acquiring context. The CPoC sunset schedule makes scheme/path verification time-sensitive [P13-P15].
- PSS Secure/3-D Secure addresses card-not-present authentication. It is not a replacement for MPoC, QR scheme approvals, or an acceptance settlement engine.
- NBE draft NDPS actions are proposals unless separately adopted or prescribed; no grant, merchant fee, QR interchange or new escrow permissions are assumed.
- Privacy processing, bank contracts, consumer protection, national settlement and electronic record finality require written advice from qualified local counsel and the actual contracting participants.

End of S03 | Baseline pre-audit assessment. Only a later signed, evidence-linked version may be designated "internally verified".